

The 'average' pay for your job is higher than what you actually make

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · cheatgrid.com

An average gets pulled up by the highest earners in whatever group was counted, and that group may not match your title, experience or region. The number can move without anyone's pay moving.

THE GOAL

You're trying to judge your own pay against something real. Check whether the page says mean or median, and go with the median figure.

CHECKLIST

You've just found a number on a page or in a headline, a quoted 'average' or 'typical' pay figure for your job, and it's sitting higher than what you actually make.

- ☐ Check whether the page calls the number a 'mean,' a plain 'average' (treat that as a mean too), or a 'median.'
- ☐ If it's a mean, look on the same page or report for a median or 'typical' figure, and go with **that one instead**.
- ☐ If a report says pay 'rose' for your field, check whether that's a total before assuming your own pay moved.
- ☐ Check what the figure covers: job title, experience level, and region. If none of those match yours, don't compare it straight to your own pay.
- ☐ Check whether the figure is 'total pay' (with bonuses) or 'regular pay' (base only); bonuses make it less comparable to yours.
- ☐ If the source shows a range, a highest-to-lowest spread, or a chart, look at it to see how wide the gap actually runs.
- ☐ Write the exact figure, which kind of average it is, and where you found it, in one place, so you don't redo this search later.
- ☐ Look for a second figure that matches your own title, level, region, and experience specifically, not the whole occupation.
- ☐ If you're thinking about raising this with your manager, gather two or three matching figures, your role, level, and region, before that conversation.
- ☐ If you're thinking about quitting or job hunting over this number, hold that decision until you've checked a figure that actually matches your job.
- ☐ If a coworker's pay comes up, a website or a shared spreadsheet, check whether it's typical or an outlier before you react.
- ☐ Once you've written the matching figure down, close the tab and **stop searching** for more pay comparisons today.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Your own gut sense of where you stand isn't a reliable check either, however good it feels.
- 2 Learning you earn less than a reported figure can genuinely **sour how you feel** about your job.
- 3 An 'average pay' rise can happen simply because the group being counted now leans toward higher-paying roles, with your own pay never moving at all.

What the number is actually counting

KNOW

A quoted 'average' salary is usually a mean, dragged upward by a few **very high earners** in your field. A single extreme income added to a small group can pull the mean higher than most people in it earn. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Statisticians openly say 'average' earnings aren't what an average person actually earns. That gap is built into the term.

Statistics offices use 'average' as a technical label for the mean, a different calculation than 'typical.' [Source 2](#)

KNOW

A pay average can include bonus payments on top of salary, and bonuses run high in industries like finance while being close to nothing in the public sector. That can inflate the figure far more than anything in your own paycheck.

Bonus pay swings the total sharply where it's common and barely moves it where it isn't. [Source 3](#)

How to read where you personally stand

WATCH

Your own gut sense of where you stand isn't a reliable check either, however good it feels.

People guessing their own place in the income ladder **cluster near the middle**, however far off that middle actually is. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Across a whole country's real pay data, close to two in three employees earned under the mean, not over it.

Pay usually takes this shape: a skewed tail of high earners sits above where most of the group falls. [Source 5](#)

WATCH

Learning you earn less than a reported figure can genuinely **sour how you feel** about your job.

People who learned they earned below their unit's median reported lower satisfaction and were more likely to start job hunting. [Source 6](#)

Whether a rising number means anything for you

KNOW

Pay 'rising' on average only tells you the total moved. Your own pay can stay exactly where it was.

A mean reflects the whole group's total, not what happened to any single person inside it. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

An 'average pay' rise can happen simply because the group being counted now leans toward higher-paying roles, with your own pay never moving at all.

The figure reflects the whole mix of jobs counted that month, and that mix keeps shifting on its own. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If a group's 'average' pay is higher than mine, then more than half the people in it must be earning more than me too.

ACTUALLY

A guaranteed half-above, half-below split only holds for a median. Pay is usually reported as a **mean**, and a mean sits wherever the highest earners drag it, often well above the point where half the group truly sits. [Source 8](#)

Sources

1. <http://downloads.bbc.co.uk/rmhttp/guidelines/editorialguidelines/pdfs/ReportingStatistics.pdf>
2. <https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/understanding-statistics/guide-labour-statistics/earnings-guide/average-earnings-guide>
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4. http://sedici.unlp.edu.ar/bitstream/handle/10915/45909/Documento_completo.pdf?sequence=1

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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Numbers in the news at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)